Desert Awakening

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Post-Canon, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Magic, Desert, Angst with a Happy Ending, Hurt/Comfort, Heat Stroke, Healing, Hurt Adora (She-Ra)

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Desert Awakening

by NotMyDestiny

Summary

Adora and Catra set off on a scouting mission in the desert, but the magic there is awakening in ways they may not expect.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes



A large glowing moon hung low and hot in the sky, so bright it hurt to look at it. The desert stretched in every direction with sand shining in gold and white, endless and shimmering. The air itself almost seemed to warp in the heat of the afternoon.

Catra both hated it and loved it. She squinted out over the ridge they were standing on, one clawed hand shading her eyes, the other resting on her hip. Adora stood beside her with a wide smile, her eyes full of that maddening optimism she somehow still had after everything. Below them, the desert rolled into carved canyons, the rock jagged and ancient.

"I know it's hot," Adora said brightly, "but isn't it beautiful?"

Catra turned just enough to give her a look. "You said the same thing about that swamp we were at last week."

"It was beautiful!" Adora exclaimed.

"Even the lilies had thorns," Catra replied.

"Still counts," Adora insisted playfully.

Catra shook her head and started climbing down the other side of the ridge. "You're lucky you're cute," she muttered.

Adora beamed. "You think I'm cute?"

"I think you're a disaster with a cute hair poof," Catra teased.

They made their way down into the canyon, their movements practiced and fluid. This was the kind of mission they both liked. It had low stakes and was quiet enough for them to just be with each other without interruptions. It was just the two of them and infinite sand.

The air in the canyon was like walking through a furnace with the heat radiating off the stone in waves. Every breath tasted like dust. Catra walked slightly ahead, tail twitching lazily behind her

with her silhouette sharp against the bright rock walls. Adora admired the view.

“So, what exactly are we looking for again?” Catra asked after a while, and then, muttering under her breath, “besides heatstroke.”

Adora held up a tracker pad and tapped the screen. “There’s an energy surge out here that the Alliance picked up last week. It’s faint, but steady. Glimmer thinks it might be coming from some kind of artifact buried out here.”

Catra raised a brow. “Let me guess, it’s ancient, mysterious, and possibly cursed?”

Adora chuckled. “We’re just scouting and maybe doing some excavation later if we find anything.”

“And by we, you mean me digging while you lift rocks twice your size and pretend it’s not impressive,” Catra said.

“Well,” Adora said, grinning, “you do look really good when you’re dusty and mad at me.”

Catra gave her a long-suffering sigh, but her eyes glinted with amusement.

The canyon opened up into a wider basin. They paused under the shade of a rock overhang. The air was cooler here, just barely, and they sat for a moment to drink water and catch their breath.

Adora flopped down beside Catra, letting her head tip back. “I like missions like this.”

Catra glanced at her. “Desert baking us alive, nothing confirmed, and endless hiking. Sure, it’s a dream.”

Adora bumped her shoulder. “No, I mean, just getting to be with you. Just us out here together, with no more war. It feels nice.”

Catra looked at her for a long second. Then, softly, “Yeah. It does.”

They sat in comfortable silence for a bit. Eventually, Adora pulled out the tracker pad again. “We’re close to the energy source. Just a bit more that way.”

Catra stood, stretching, ears twitching forward. “Well, lead the way, dummy. Let’s go find your ancient non-cursed treasure.”

Adora hopped up, brushing sand off her pants. “I don’t know. I think I already found the real treasure.”

Catra groaned. “You did not just say that. You’re impossible.”

“And yet, you’re still here.” Adora smiled.

They started walking again across the hot sand. The glowing moon beat down, and the air shimmered, and somewhere ahead, there was something to uncover. But for now, it was just them and the desert, and the way their laughter echoed off the canyon walls, bright and real.

The desert grew quieter as they walked. Almost like the land itself was holding its breath. The fur along the back of Catra’s neck lifted just slightly. She glanced sideways at Adora, who had her head down, scanning the canyon with the little device still pinging softly in her hand. The tracker pad beeped again, this time louder.

Adora paused, blinking at the readout. “Okay, that’s definitely stronger. We’re right on top of it.”

Catra slowed to a halt beside her and crouched down, running her fingers through the sand. It was pale gold here, more silt than grit, silky and fine. Her claws scraped something hard not far beneath the surface. “Something’s under here,” she said. “Something flat. It doesn’t feel natural.”

Adora crouched beside her. “Like a structure?”

“Or a rock with delusions of grandeur,” Catra said.

Adora grinned. “Let’s find out.”

They dug for a while, Catra with sharp precision and Adora with sheer enthusiasm. The heat pressed down hard, sweat beading at Adora’s temples, but it didn’t faze her. Her hands were covered in dust, and every now and then she brushed her face with the back of her wrist, leaving pale sunlit streaks on her rosy cheeks. Catra didn’t say anything about how beautiful she looked like that, but she noticed.

After maybe fifteen minutes, Adora had more fully uncovered the artifact. It was solid stone that was smooth, carved, and cool despite the heat. “Whoa,” she breathed. “Catra, look.”

Catra crouched beside her, brushing more sand away. Symbols emerged that were faint and worn down by centuries of wind, but looked magical and ancient. Lines spiraled outward from a central point, both geometric and organic, all at once.

“Definitely not just a rock,” Catra muttered.

Adora touched the center. She felt a faint hum of magic under her fingers, like a memory half-woken. “It feels… familiar,” she murmured.

Catra narrowed her eyes. “You’ve seen this before?”

“Not exactly. I don’t think this is First Ones tech. It feels magical, but like a type of magic I’ve felt somewhere before.” She looked up, her brows furrowed.

They both stared at it for a while, crouched under the brutal light of a burning desert moon, dust caking their clothes, and the wind tousling their hair. The artifact felt odd and mysterious.

Catra broke the silence first. “You’re not about to start glowing again, are you?”

“Unclear,” Adora said with a helpless smile.

Catra stood, brushing her hands off. “Okay, let’s mark the coordinates and send the readings back to Bright Moon.”

After logging the details on the tracker pad, they backed off slowly. The stone stayed still and quiet, but it still felt like they should use some caution. Like the magic might not mind them looking, but they needed to be wary of disturbing it further. They climbed back to the ridge where the air felt less tense. Adora pinged their findings back to Bright Moon and tucked the tracker pad away.

“So,” Catra said, arms folded, ears twitching lazily, “do you think the desert’s flirting with you now, too, or is this just your standard, draws in wild magic like a magnet, situation?”

“I think it’s more of a polite hello,” Adora said.

“Let’s hope it stays polite.”

The sky began to fade to dusk. The shadows stretched long behind them, and even the heat felt like it was finally starting to ease its grip. They set up camp just below the ridge, near a cluster of wind-smoothed boulders. There wasn’t much shelter, but the view was stunning with endless dunes painted in gold and rose tones in the twilight.

Catra dropped her gear and flopped dramatically onto her back. “Next mission, we go somewhere with trees and shade. Somewhere cool and not made of sand.”

Adora chuckled, sitting down beside her. “I thought you liked it here.”

“I like you. I’m tolerating the desert.”

Adora leaned over and kissed her forehead. “Noted.”

They lay side by side under the open sky with the magic still slumbering beneath the sands and the air cooling with nightfall. The stars would come soon, and the desert would shift again, just as ancient and mysterious in the dark. For now, they rested, two figures in the vast quiet, wrapped in the comfort of one another.

Chapter End Notes

> When I was doing research for this story, I learned that Etheria has no sun and just moons that provide it with heat and light, so I incorporated that into the story.

Chapter 2

The desert was not silent at dawn. Winds blew steadily and smoothly through the dunes, lifting thin trails of dust that shimmered in the first pale light and then settled over everything. But where they'd made camp below the ridge, it felt oddly quieter now than even the still of night.

Adora stirred before the morning moon had even cracked the horizon. Her eyes blinked open slowly, chasing the remnants of some dream she couldn't quite recall about something vast and old. She rolled onto her side, squinting up at the paling dark, and sat before she even realized she was moving.

Her breath caught, and she felt something within her. Not sharp, but strange, like gravity turned sideways. It was as if some gentle, invisible thread had looped around her chest and was now tugging steadily like a summons. It was like a call she couldn't seem to ignore, that compelled her to follow it. Her boots hit the ground before her thoughts could catch up. She moved on instinct and with certainty.

Catra didn't stir as she passed. She lay curled on a cloak, tail twitching faintly with dreams. The rise and fall of her shoulders was steady and peaceful. Adora hesitated beside her for a heartbeat, but then the pull deepened. It was like something had noticed her hesitation and increased its call, and she was compelled once more to follow it. Her steps seemed to carry her away before she could even think to resist.

The stone artifact they'd uncovered yesterday remained still, sleeping beneath its dust. Adora knew she was heading somewhere different now. She moved steadily, with a strange surety, through the sand and up toward the ridge. Soon the sand gave way to smooth stone, and after a substantial walk, she descended into a long, narrow passage, one she didn't remember from their earlier scouting.

The walls of rock pressed in close, etched with barely visible spirals and runes too old to name. Her feet clung to the path as if they'd walked it before, though she was sure they had not. The air began to change, becoming heavier, and it felt laced with magic that hummed almost like it was breathing around her.

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Catra woke to warmth on her face and an aching emptiness beside her. A moon had begun its slow ascent over the canyon rim, painting everything in washed-out gold. Heat clung to the rocks, already pressing against her skin and promising a blistering day ahead.

She shifted, tail flicking instinctively toward where Adora should've been, solid and warm and always sprawling into her space. Now, though, there was only a rumpled cloak.

Catra blinked and sat up with her ears twitching. "Adora?"

Nothing but the low hush of the desert wind.

She rubbed at her eyes and muttered to herself. "Probably out doing some heroic sunrise stretching or communing with a cactus or whatever it is she thinks counts as routine."

Catra stood, shaking sand from her fur and glanced around the camp. She half-expected to spot Adora standing on a rock somewhere, hands on her hips, hair backlit by morning light like a dramatic poster child for valor. But, she did not see her anywhere.

Her brow furrowed. "Okay, where'd you wander off to this time…"

There was no note or message and no boot-prints circling back toward their camp. Instead, there was just one clear set of prints heading away and up toward the ridge with a too sure stride. Something prickled at the base of her neck, and Catra cursed under her breath as she grabbed her canteen, knife, and cloak before setting off at a quick, purposeful pace.

The prints were easy enough to follow at first. They were crisp edges in the sand that were spaced with the long stride of someone not wandering, but sure of where they were heading. Catra's stomach twisted as she followed them. It wasn't like Adora to just walk off without a word, especially not here, in a place laced with old magic.

The higher Catra climbed, the quieter the desert became. The sound of the wind had faltered, and now it was just stone and heat and silence everywhere. She crested the ridge, eyes scanning the wide basin beyond, expecting to see a flash of blond hair or anything to show her where Adora had gone, but there was nothing at all.

"Damn it," she whispered.

She checked the sand again. The tracks now faded onto harder ground, sun-bleached smooth stone making them untraceable. Catra prowled forward carefully, eyes darting across every rock face, every shadow, but still she found nothing.

"Adora," she called out loudly, her voice cracking in the dry air.

There was still no response. Just the whisper of wind curling around her ankles like a taunt.

Her jaw tightened. "Okay, sure. Don't answer. That's just fine. That's not completely terrifying at all."

She moved faster, scanning every ridge and dip in the land, checking behind outcroppings and under ledges. Her breath quickened, not from effort but from creeping dread. It wasn't just that Adora was gone. It was that she felt taken somehow.

Catra stopped at the edge of a canyon wall, eyes sweeping the horizon. The desert stretched out ahead of her, endless and glowing, but so empty.

Her voice dropped, the fight edging out of it. "Where are you…"

Only the wind answered, and Catra stood alone, the tracks behind her swallowed by dust, her claws curling into fists at her sides.

***

A small hidden basin opened before Adora, surrounded by cracked stone in a near-perfect ring, like something had broken through from beneath. And at the center stood a tall, narrow monolith of red-gold stone. It was like a jagged shard of fire erupting from the ground. Unknown spiraling rune-like images were carved lightly along its face and glowed like faint embers.

Adora stepped forward, and everything changed. A sudden wave of energy surged through her veins and pulled her against the monolith. She gasped, or tried to. Her breath caught halfway as her body felt a sudden wave of paralysis. Her legs locked, and her arms twitched and then fell still. She couldn’t move at all.

Panic flickered at the edge of her awareness, but even that felt far away. The monolith pulsed, and Adora stood paralyzed and caught in its grasp.

Chapter 3

Adora stood pressed with her back against the monolith, and every muscle trembling with her intense but futile efforts at resistance. The magic hummed all around her, and it seemed to even reverberate through her. She couldn't move and couldn't speak. She couldn't lift a hand or even shift her weight. Her body just did not respond to her will. Her feet felt rooted into the stone beneath her.

She reached for She-Ra, trying to call forth the power and light inside her, but her magic didn't answer. It was still there, somewhere within her, but right now it was distant and unattainable. She tried again, even harder this time, pushing toward it with all her might, but still there was nothing.

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Catra searched in widening circles, scanning the sand and climbing over dunes. Every second she didn't see Adora, the dread grew heavier. Catra's ears twitched at every whisper of wind, her claws flexing restlessly at her sides.

"Adora!" Her voice cracked against endless sand and stone. Catra's pulse leapt, and she dug her claws along the rock. "Adora!" she called again, even louder and more desperate, like a plea.

The canyon carried her voice back to her, mocking in its emptiness.

Catra forced herself forward, step by step, the desert wind howling at her back.

***

As the hours of the morning passed, a fiery moon climbed higher into the sky, and the heat sharpened like a blade. Sweat ran down Adora's neck and back. She thought of water and Catra and longed desperately for both. Sweat streaked down her temple,

caught in her lashes and stung her eyes as the heat pressed against her skin. She tried again to pull away from the monolith, but her legs stayed rooted.

Adora's body felt like it was turning against her now. Her legs trembled violently. She begged them to move, to do something, but they stayed locked in place. Sweat began to pour off of her, soaking her shirt until the fabric clung against her, heavy and damp. Her hair was plastered to her forehead, and a low pressure at the base of her skull began to increase, matching the pounding of the heat.

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By midday, Catra was running. A measured run, the kind trained into her to cover ground without wasting too much energy. Her feet pounded sand and stone, cloak draped over her shoulder, and sweat beading on her fur.

"Adora!" she shouted again, voice echoing uselessly off the canyon walls. "Come on, please just answer me!"

She stopped to catch her breath in the shade of a ridge, squinting down into a new expanse of stone and sand, but it was just another dead end. She clenched her jaw and kept moving. She knew Adora couldn't have just vanished. Still, the desert offered no answers, but just more dry wind and shimmering heat and stretching silence.

Time began to blur. She drank in sips from her canteen and carefully rationed what she had. She checked and rechecked the same paths in ever-widening circles. The silence pressed back heavier than the heat. Catra pushed forward, scanning every crack and every shadow.

Her chest tightened with something raw and heavy, the kind of fear that was suffocating, curling tightly around her ribs. Her tail lashed in agitation. Her ears twitched to every sound, though there were none except the relentless desert wind. The emptiness

itself was unbearable. Catra dropped to her knees at the ridge, tail coiling tight around her legs and claws digging into the sand. She scanned the basin below, nothing but rock and haze.

"No," she hissed under her breath. "No, no, no."

And she pushed forward again, climbing down the ridge, desperate as she scanned every crack in the canyon, every shimmer of light on the stone.

"Adora!" Her voice cracked, hoarse and raw, breaking in the middle.

The echo came back hollow and taunting.

She cursed under her breath, digging claws into her palm hard enough to sting. It did nothing to cut the gnawing panic in her chest. She scanned the canyon walls, claws scraping against stone as she pulled herself up the next ledge.

Catra's ears pricked as she crested it. The desert stretched wide and empty beneath her. She scrambled down again, scanning every outcropping, every overhang, and forcing herself not to imagine the worst. Her eyes burned, but she blinked fiercely against it. She would not give in to the panic, not until she had Adora in front of her, alive and safe.

She pushed herself back to her feet, eyes scanning every bluff and every shadow. "I'm coming," she promised under her breath. "I don't care what it takes. I'm coming."

***

Adora's knees threatened to buckle, but the magic kept her upright and forced her to stand. She felt like a puppet being held up by invisible strings. Her head hung forward as much as the magic allowed, and strands of hair clung to her sweat-damp face.

She tried to breathe steadily, but her panic was starting to rise. She was trapped and burning alive in the desert heat. Every

second felt like it was pulling her further from herself. Her heart hammered, feeling strange and out of rhythm.

Her thoughts began to slur. Words came slower. Her vision blurred at the edges. The sky was too blue and too wide. It made her dizzy just trying to look at it. Sweat no longer dripped, but just dried instantly on her overheated skin.

The headache throbbed harder, beating in rhythm with her too-fast heart. She couldn't even lift a hand to press against her temple. She was locked in place with her breath coming in ragged pants, and dizziness rolling over her in waves. Her thoughts tangled now, skipping and repeating.

***

Every step wound Catra tighter. Her ears caught phantom sounds like a faint cry that was probably just the wind. Adora was out there, and she was sure now that she was not okay.

"Come on, dummy," Catra muttered, her voice trembling despite her best effort to sound sharp. "Give me something. A signal. Anything."

She stopped again mid-step with her ears flicking. There was a quiet feeling, almost like a whisper. It felt like something magical. It came from farther west and was like a humming or vibration. Catra turned toward it, her eyes narrowing as her claws flexed unconsciously.

She didn't know what she was heading toward, and at this point she didn't care. All she knew was that it was the first possible lead she'd had all day, and she was done waiting for the desert to give her a clearer answer. She started running again, chasing this whisper of something strange.

"Hold on," she murmured, a plea carried to no one. "I'll find you. Just hold on, please."

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The magic continued to force Adora upright. She swayed against the invisible hold, locked in a stance she no longer had the strength to maintain. Her vision blurred with the edges going soft.

The world tilted. She blinked against the dizzy haze as her vision wavered and the shapes of the stone around her bent and twisted until her stomach lurched. Her knees quivered again, and this time she wished the magic would just let her fall. She wanted to close her eyes, to sink down and rest, but the magic held her upright. She swayed and trembled, her body a prisoner in the heat.

Adora's heart was now a frantic pounding. Her head throbbed mercilessly with pain radiating from behind her eyes until the whole world pulsed with it. Light stabbed at her vision until she had to squint through the blur. Rocks swam in front of her eyes, twisting and shifting until they seemed alive. They pulsed in time with her frantic heartbeat in a disorienting dance. Adora stood powerless, her body beginning to shut down.

Chapter 4

Catra ran toward the whisper of magic that brushed at the edge of her senses, driving her forward, her ears pressed flat against her head. She approached a basin carved into the stone hidden behind an outcrop of jagged rock so that it could only be seen from just the right angle. She paused at the edge as her eyes landed on the red-gold monolith. Standing before it on the edge of consciousness but still somehow upright was Adora.

Catra's heart lurched at the sight, and she called out desperately, "Adora!"

Adora didn't move or respond. Her eyes were open but unfocused and glassy. Her face was flushed deep with heat, her jaw slack, and her chest rising in shallow breaths.

Catra was down the rocks in seconds, stumbling, sliding, and sprinting to get to her faster. As she skidded to a stop before it, the monolith gave a low pulse, and its glow faded. The grip holding Adora broke, and Catra dove to catch her before she could hit the ground.

Catra flinched at the heat of Adora in her arms. "You're burning hot."

Adora's head lolled a bit to the side, the most acknowledgment she could seem to give.

Catra pressed a hand to her cheek and then her neck. "You're overheating badly. How long have you…?" Her voice was shaking as her fear mounted.

The shade at the base of the stone was thin, but it was all she had, and she half-carried, half-dragged Adora just far enough into it to shield her. Catra rolled her cloak in one swift motion and pressed it beneath Adora's head.

Adora pulled her into focus, and a single soft word escaped from her lips. “Catra…”

Catra’s attention instantly snapped back to her. “I’m right here.”

“You… found me,” Adora managed to reply.

“Of course I found you, you idiot.” She pressed her forehead against Adora’s temple, the heat radiating from her skin almost too much to bear. “You wandered off into cursed rock country and didn’t think I’d come looking?”

Adora let out the faintest ghost of a laugh that turned into a groan.

“We need to get you out of here,” Catra murmured. “Stay with me, okay?” she whispered, her voice low and fierce.

Adora’s eyes fluttered again. “Tried… couldn’t move…”

“I know.” Catra cupped her cheek gently. “It’s okay. I’ve got you now.”

Adora’s body trembled, still conscious, somehow, but only just.

Catra yanked the canteen from her belt and gave it a small shake. There was not nearly enough, but it would have to do for now. She uncapped it and dribbled water onto Adora’s lips to coax her. “Come on, drink,” she urged. Catra tilted her up a little more, letting her take a few sips before having to pull it away.

Then she poured the last bit of the water over a scrap of fabric and pressed it to Adora’s forehead, neck, wrists - anywhere she remembered from training or desperation. “Come on,” she muttered. “Cool down. You’re not burning up on me now.”

Adora flinched at the cool touch, and her muscles spasmed. She let out a quiet groan and blinked as if it were the greatest effort.

“Hey. Hey.” Catra knelt close. “Eyes on me. That’s right. Stay with me.”

Adora turned toward her voice. Her lips parted, but all that came out was a dry rasp.

“It’s okay. Don’t try to talk. Just breathe.”

But Adora’s breaths were shallow, fast, and wrong. Her skin was far too hot and her face far too red. Her hair stuck to her forehead, soaked and matted. Her hands trembled, fingers twitching like her body didn’t quite know what it was doing anymore.

Catra fought down her rising panic at seeing Adora in this precarious state. She turned and crouched again beside Adora, who was still trembling. “I need you to hang in there, okay?” Catra whispered, brushing her fingers across her burning cheek. “I know you can’t hear me very well right now, but I’m not going anywhere. I’m staying with you.”

Adora gave the faintest nod. Maybe, at this point, it was hard to tell anymore.

Catra’s hands shook as she fumbled through Adora’s belt pack until her claws brushed the cool metal of the tracker pad. She yanked it free and jabbed at it desperately until it flared to life. Catra quickly tried to open a channel. “Come on, come on…”

“Catra?” Glimmer’s sharp voice came through. “We’ve been trying to reach you for hours-“

“It’s Adora,” Catra cut in. “She’s bad. She’s overheating. Got caught in some kind of magical trap. I don’t know. She’s barely conscious. You need to get us out of here now.”

“Coordinates,” Glimmer responded sharply.

Catra sent them.

“I found it,” came Bow’s voice in the background. “Hold on. We’re coming.”

Catra dropped the pad and turned back to Adora, kneeling beside her once more. “Help’s coming,” she murmured, voice trembling despite her best effort to keep it steady. “You hear me? Just hang on.”

“Catra…”

“I‘m here,” Catra whispered, adjusting her cloak beneath Adora’s head and pressing the damp cloth to her cheek. “Stay with me, dummy, just a little longer.”

The air shimmered pink, and Glimmer and Bow appeared. The moment they saw Adora, the color drained from both their faces.

“Oh no,” Bow muttered.

“She’s close to heatstroke,” Catra said in desperation. “I’ve been trying to cool her, but she’s not coming back down.”

Glimmer dropped to her knees beside Adora. “We’ll help. Hold tight.”

With practiced efficiency, Glimmer cast a cooling spell and then readied to teleport them out.

Catra scooped Adora up with a tender look, “I’ve got you.”

Glimmer’s magic wrapped around them, and the desert heat quickly gave way to the cool air of Bright Moon’s infirmary. Healers surged forward to meet them. As they placed Adora onto a cot, Catra gripped her too-hot hand and didn't let go.

Chapter 5

The healers said Adora wasn't in any danger anymore. The fever was coming down. The cooling spells and hydrating elixirs they'd administered were doing their job. But Catra couldn't truly believe it yet. It wasn't that she thought they were lying, but because Adora still looked pretty bad. Her cheeks were still flushed a too-bright red, and her eyes were glassy and unfocused. Her breathing had eased, but it still wasn't quite right.

Catra hadn't left the room even once. She sat at Adora's bedside with her knees drawn up to her chest and one hand still wrapped tightly around Adora's. Just trying to hold her steady. A hum of healing magic surrounded Adora, and a clean and slightly herbal scent drifted through the room.

"You know," Catra muttered softly, more to fill the silence than anything else, "you scared about ten years off my life today." It still felt wrong to see Adora lying still and weak when she was usually so strong.

Adora stirred slightly, her fingers twitching against Catra's.

"Not that I had ten years to spare," Catra added, voice lower now. "So, if you're gonna do that again, a little warning, okay?"

Adora's lips moved.

Catra leaned in immediately. "What?"

Another breath, and this time the words came softly. "Didn't mean… to scare you…"

Catra's eyes widened, and she didn't know how to feel. She felt like she might laugh or cry or maybe even collapse. Instead, she managed to reach out and gently push some hair off Adora's damp forehead. "Yeah, well, you did."

Adora looked up at her. Her eyes were starting to be a bit clearer now. It wasn't much, but it let Catra breathe just a little easier. "I'm… okay?" Adora asked like she was trying to convince herself.

"Yeah," Catra said softly, tightening her grip on Adora's hand. "You're okay now. You're here and you're safe." Then she added, "And you're not allowed to go near any more creepy glowing monoliths unless I personally throw a rock at it first."

Adora gave the smallest smile, exhausted, but real. "Deal…"

Catra didn't smile back. She still couldn't yet. "You should rest."

Adora's fingers shifted in Catra's hand. "Only if… you stay…"

Catra's chest tightened at that soft request. "Of course I'm staying. I'm not going anywhere."

She shifted to sit on the edge of the cot and gently placed their joined hands between them. Her tail curled up and brushed against Adora's side. The light in the room dimmed as night fell. Adora slept, her breathing now deep and slow. Catra kept watch for a long while, a bit afraid that she might wake to find Adora worse somehow. Images of her paralyzed in the desert still hauntingly clear in her mind.

Morning light filtered through the high windows of the Bright Moon infirmary. Adora stirred before her eyes opened. She noticed that her breaths came deeper and easier now. Her body, though still weak and aching, felt like it belonged to her again. Her throat still felt dry, but the desperate feeling of thirst had lifted. The ache behind her eyes was dull now and distant. She felt much better. Her eyes opened and focused on Catra.

She was slumped beside the cot with her head resting against the mattress, tail curled around her ankles. Her ears twitched faintly in her sleep. One of her hands still held Adora's, fingers loose but not letting go. Catra had held onto her all night, and Adora felt so loved.

Adora turned her head slightly. The motion made her a little dizzy, but she didn't care. She brought Catra's hand to her chest and held it there, over her heart, just for a moment.

Catra stirred, mumbling something that became, "Adora?"

Adora gave her hand a soft squeeze. "Hey…"

Catra sat up fast, blinking hard like she wasn't sure if she'd heard right. "You're awake?"

"I am," Adora said with a small smile.

Catra let out a shaky breath and looked her over. Her color and breathing had returned to normal now. "You're okay. You're actually you."

"Well," Adora said, "as much as I ever am."

That earned a relieved laugh. Catra reached up and brushed her thumb across Adora's cheek. "Don't joke when I haven't slept."

"You did," Adora said, her voice a little stronger. "I saw you."

Catra was a little caught off guard. "Only because I knew you were past the worst of it. You really scared me this time."

Adora's eyes softened. "I'm sorry."

"Don't apologize," Catra said quietly, brushing a strand of hair from her forehead. "Just don't do it again."

"I didn't exactly plan it."

Catra smirked faintly. "Next time we're scouting, I'm handcuffing you to me."

Adora let out a laugh and winced a bit, her body still weak. "Please don't. That would be so sweaty." Adora let her head sink deeper into the pillow, but kept smiling. "I missed you."

“I found you as soon as I could.”

“I know,” she whispered. “I felt you. Even when I couldn’t think straight… I knew you were there.”

Catra leaned down and kissed her forehead. “I’ll always find you.”

They lay in silence for a while, Catra still holding her hand, finally letting herself breathe now that Adora’s eyes were clear and warm again.

Eventually, Adora murmured, “You should sleep more.”

“I will,” Catra said. “Later, but right now I just want to watch you be alive for a little while longer.”

Adora gave her a tired smile. “Okay.”

And so Catra stayed awake, her heart steadier than it had been all day, with the warm weight of Adora’s hand in hers and morning light drifting slowly across the floor.

Chapter 6

Recovery came slowly, and Adora hated how hard that was for her. She hated that her body had trembled when all she'd done was try to sit up. Hated that she couldn't walk a few steps without needing support. She really hated that she couldn't seem to just transform into She-Ra and be instantly fixed. Her magic seemed distant, like it was tucked away from her. And most of all, she hated the worried looks from Catra. Wonderful Catra, who had saved her and barely ever left her side, but couldn't hide the constant concern in her eyes.

Adora so wanted to just be back to normal. Catra would tell her not to push herself and to take it slow, and Adora knew she should try to listen. But, she just couldn't help but push and try harder to be back to herself again.

Adora draped her legs over the edge of the cot and tried to stand on her own. But, just as soon as she was up, she immediately collapsed back against Catra.

The smug, "Told you to take it easy," chafed. But then those clawed hands were so gently and carefully easing her back down into her pillows. Their fingers were entwined once more, and Adora couldn't help but let her frustrations ease. Catra brushed the hair back from her face and cupped her cheek. She pressed their foreheads together and told her softly, "You're getting there."

Glimmer and Bow stopped by that afternoon.

"You're looking a lot better now, Adora," Bow greeted, and Glimmer agreed.

Then Bow launched quickly into gushing about his discoveries. "We've been going through all the readings from the tracker pad on the monolith's energy. It's definitely not First Ones tech. I think it's some type of old and wild magic."

Bow leaned in. “Whatever it is, it recognized your magic when you touched the first stone and somehow connected with it and used that to control you and bring you to the Monolith.”

Adora’s gaze dropped to her lap. “It still feels like it’s a little bit in me or something. Like now my magic won't settle right.”

“We’ll figure it out,” Glimmer said softly. “For now, just rest and let yourself heal.”

Catra listened to the discussion and didn’t chime in. Later, when Glimmer and Bow were gone, she sat beside Adora again and said, “You always take the weight of everything on like it’s your job to carry all of Etheria on your back.”

Adora smiled faintly. “Old habits.”

“Well,” Catra said with her voice quiet but firm, “this time, you're not carrying it alone. I won’t let you.”

Adora smiled over at her, and Catra returned it, steady and warm.

They returned to their room that night, which was nice even if the walk there had consisted of far more leaning against Catra than Adora wanted. Well, on one hand, on the other, being close to her like that was always nice.

Catra helped Adora gently into their bed and lay beside her with such care. Adora let her head rest against Catra’s shoulder, and they drifted off to sleep together.

The next day, Adora was walking a bit better, and they ventured outside. It was nice to feel the glow of the moons on her skin, pleasant and not blazing like the one in the desert. Her strength was steadily returning. She was still tired quickly, and her balance was a bit off. There were occasional moments where her legs trembled and she felt like she was trying to convince her body that it still belonged to her, but she was upright on her own and not toppling over, so it was a win.

Still, though she couldn’t transform. Even feeling stronger, being focused and determined the magic didn’t respond. She reached inward but there wasn't even a flicker. It rattled her, and Catra, who noticed everything, could sense her unease.

Later that afternoon, they sat side by side in the Bright Moon garden. Adora leaned back against a wall, her thoughts bouncing around her head.

“You’ve got a look,” Catra said.

“What?”

“A look that says you’re trying not to panic and to fix everything on your own.”

Adora rolled her eyes affectionately. “I just… it’s weird not being able to feel my magic. It’s like something’s blocking it off.”

“Maybe it’s waiting for you to stop trying so hard,” Catra said.

“Or maybe I broke it.”

Catra raised an eyebrow. “Don’t be dumb.”

Before Adora could reply, Glimmer and Bow joined them, dropping onto the grass beside them. Bow offered a grin. “We’ve been running simulations.”

Adora raised a brow. “Simulations of what?”

“Of what happens if the desert magic destabilizes further. Its energy is pulsing stronger each day.”

“It’s like it woke up,” Bow added. “And it doesn’t like that it was disturbed.”

Adora frowned. “Then we’ll have to find a way to calm it. I can still help, even without transforming.”

“You will transform again,” Glimmer said firmly. “But either way, we’re not putting you back out there alone.”

“I wouldn’t let her go alone even if she could transform,” Catra muttered. “Not after last time.”

Glimmer nodded. “We’ve been trying to determine its magical frequency. If we can figure out what it’s reacting to, what it wants, we might be able to stabilize it somehow.”

Adora leaned toward her, “Do you think it’s alive?”

Glimmer hesitated. “Maybe not like we are. But it's aware in some way. It responded to you.”

“Maybe it needs something,” Bow said. “Or maybe it’s just old and angry.”

Catra added dryly, “So basically, the angry magical desert is lashing out like a cranky toddler, and we’re going to have to go in and give it a hug?”

Glimmer laughed. “That’s one way to put it.”

Adora smiled despite herself. “I’m good at hugs.”

Catra shot her a look. “You’re not hugging anything until we know it’s safe.”

“We’ll keep working on it. You keep resting, and we’ll face it together when the time comes,” Bow said.

Chapter 7

Nights at Bright Moon were cool, peaceful and quiet. Moonlight cast a silverish gleam throughout the bedroom, and the soft rustle of trees in the breeze was a steady comfort. Darkness had deepened around them, and Adora and Catra were asleep close beside one another.

But tonight, the grip of a dream had taken hold of Adora. Heat pressed in from a blazing hot moon. Her body was trapped, held up standing despite a feeling of unbearable fatigue. Her heart and head pounded relentlessly, and her thirst was overwhelming. Her mind swirled with dizziness and panic. She knew she was back at the monolith in the desert.

But something was different this time. The monolith pulsed with its magical energy, and now an otherworldly voice echoed around and through her. “You are not strong enough. You are not worthy. You are not ready.”

Adora strained against the magic holding her in place and tried to transform and summon She-Ra, but her magic recoiled from her and slipped from her grasp.

The haunting voice intensified, “You are nothing, and you never were.”

Adora awoke in a fearful panic with a sudden gasp, and Catra startled awake beside her. “Adora?” She reached instinctively toward her.

A feeling of dread overwhelmed Adora. Her heart was pounding, her skin covered in sweat, her breath coming irregularly as she tried to will herself to calm down. She could feel that she was back in the cool air of her room in Bright Moon once more, but the panic gripped her so tightly it was almost like her mind wouldn't accept that as reality.

Catra's voice was soft now and laced with concern, "Hey. Hey. It's okay. You're okay. Did you have a nightmare?"

Adora nodded and pressed her face into Catra's chest.

"Were you back in the desert?"

"Yeah," Adora whispered, finally finding her voice. "It… it talked to me this time. The magic, I think."

Catra stilled at that. "What did it say?"

Adora opened her mouth to speak, but her throat seemed to close up again for a moment. She took in a ragged breath. "It…" Her voice cracked. "It said I wasn't strong enough. That I'd never been. That I wasn't worthy." The words tumbled out in a rush, and her fear was palpable. "It… it felt so real, Catra. Like it knew me. Like it was right."

"No," Catra said in a firm voice. "No, Adora. It's not right."

"But what if…" Adora's breath hitched again. "What if I can't do this? What if I go back out there and that magic just… undoes me again? I couldn't move, I couldn't speak… I could barely think. I was just trapped in my own body and burning alive. And now that magic it's in my head and talking to me. What if next time it doesn't let go?" Her voice shook, and tears pricked at her eyes. She was ashamed of her fears, of how all her strength felt like it had suddenly slipped away from her.

Catra reached out, cupping Adora's face between her hands and guiding her gently to meet her eyes. "Look at me," she said, steady and low. "You're here with me now. Whatever that thing is, whatever it thinks it knows about you, it's wrong."

Adora's eyes filled fully with tears now. "But I couldn't fight it."

"You will, though. You weren't ready then, and it hit you out of nowhere. That doesn't mean you can't face it now. Not with the three of us backing you. Not with me there with you." Her voice

softened as she leaned forward, resting her forehead against Adora's. "You are not alone in this."

Catra pulled Adora into her arms. The embrace was steady and loving. Adora didn't resist, she just melted into the comfort. She pressed her forehead to Catra's shoulder, trying to ground herself in Catra's scent, her warmth, her strength in this moment.

Catra held her tight, her claws rubbing slow circles across Adora's back. "I've got you," she whispered. "You're safe now."

They stayed like that for a while, curled close together as Adora's breathing finally evened out. The grip of her fear loosening its hold.

"You're everything to me," Catra said into her hair. "And I think that counts for something."

Adora let out a shaky laugh. "You're very biased."

"Damn right I am. And I'm also the one who's going to punch the next ancient magical force that messes with you."

"That's very brave of you."

"Yeah, well, I'm terrifying when I'm sleep deprived."

Adora gave her a small smile.

They lay back down together, and Catra kept her arm draped protectively around Adora's waist as they both drifted back to sleep.

The next morning, they gathered in the Council Chamber. Catra sat on the edge of a high-backed chair, her eyes sharp. Adora sat right beside her. She was nearly back to her full strength now, but still feeling a bit fragile from her lingering dream.

Glimmer was pacing. "We thought about just sealing the place off, but the magical energy is intensifying more and more."

Bow nodded, scanning his tracker pad. “We measured the energy radius two days ago. It’s nearly doubled since then.”

Adora let out a slow breath. “So containment’s not enough.”

“No,” Glimmer said. “But we need a plan. The last time you got close to that thing, it almost cooked you from the inside out.”

Adora flinched a bit, twisting her hands in her lap. “I know.”

Catra’s eyes flicked towards her protectively. “We’re not letting that happen again.”

Bow spoke gently. “Which is why we’ve been working on ways to shield you from it. At least partially. Glimmer’s been modifying shielding spells, and I’ve been analyzing its frequency.”

Glimmer added, “We’re thinking of a layered approach. First, we’ll use shielding wards. Then, a tether to keep Adora stabilized. If we can stabilize the connection before Adora even engages with the magic, we might stop the worst of it. Of course, there’s still a chance it’ll attack again.”

“And if it does?” Catra asked flatly.

Glimmer looked at Adora, then at Bow.
“We’ll be ready. We’ll go in together. No more of this draws Adora out in the middle of the night without waking anyone nonsense.”

“That was not my fault,” Adora muttered.

“No,” Catra replied. “It was the cursed desert rock’s fault. Which is exactly why we’re not letting it have another shot at that.”

Bow tapped a control crystal, and a glowing pink map flared to life above the table, a swath of desert marked with shifting energy currents, the monolith pulsing faintly at its heart.

Adora’s breath caught at the sight. It looked alive. She couldn't help but feel like it was waiting.

Bow spoke up again. “The earliest we can head back is in two days. That’ll give us time to prep the spells and let Glimmer run a few more tests. After that, we’ll make our move.”

Adora gave a slow nod. “Okay.”

Catra didn’t speak, but her fingers curled tightly against Adora’s beneath the table.

Glimmer finally stopped pacing. “We’ve faced worse, haven’t we?”

“We’ve also barely survived worse,” Catra muttered.

Adora gave her a small smile. “But we did survive.”

Catra looked at her. She studied her for a long second and then gave a brisk nod. “Yeah, we did.”

Chapter 8

They settled into a rhythm over the two days they had slated for preparation. It was a purposeful stillness, like taking a breath before the inevitable. They all leaned into the peace of the temporary calm.

In the mornings, they worked on readying themselves for what lay ahead. Glimmer practiced reinforcing and strengthening her protective shields. Bow tinkered with his tracker pad, tuning amplification signals and making careful enhancements.

Adora had started to feel her own magic returning to her a bit as well. When she reached for it, she could feel its hum there again, but just out of reach and not rising enough to transform. Still, it was a definite improvement, and she felt relieved to have even a small sign that the magic wasn't irreparably broken.

Catra and Adora worked together now with Glimmer to attempt to establish a tether. Hopefully, it would serve as another barrier that would prevent any harm when they faced the strong desert magic. Their emotional connection had been a powerful force in the past and one that they both were hoping to be able to strengthen and utilize again.

“Okay, let the flow of energy anchor between you both,” Glimmer coached.

Catra arched a brow at Adora. “Let the flow anchor? Is that some kind of meditation talk?”

Adora snorted. “Shut up and anchor your flow.”

“Romantic,” Catra smirked as she stepped closer.

“I told you,” Glimmer chimed in. “Your energy resonates better when you’re not being stubborn about it.”

“I’m never stubborn,” Catra muttered.

Adora gave her a look.

“My way is just always the right way,” she added smugly.

Adora let out an exasperated sigh, but her eyes were twinkling, and she reached out her fingers to entwine with Catra’s, who quickly gave her hand a squeeze.

They focused again and worked to hold the connection between them. A faint warmth seemed to hum in Adora’s chest at the feel of Catra trying to strengthen her. She felt steady and loved.

During the afternoons, they took the time to rest and recharge. They needed these slower moments to prepare emotionally just as much as they needed the dedicated preparation time.

Adora sat back against a warm stone wall with Catra’s head in her lap, enjoying a moment of peace and contentment. These moments meant everything. They were something the desert hadn’t been able to take from her.

Catra grumbled, “We’re not being very useful just sitting out here.”

Adora smiled down at her and combed her fingers through Catra’s hair. “You’re being quite useful, actually. You’re helping me keep my energy centered.”

“Uh-huh. Sounds like lazy She-Ra nonsense,” Catra teased, but she didn't pull away. Instead, she purred affectionately and gazed up at Adora.

They heard Bow and Glimmer’s laughter as the two approached and settled down beside them. The smell of freshly baked bread wafted from the basket of food they had brought over for a picnic.

Bow greeted them cheerfully, “Hey, guys, I actually made sandwiches that didn't fall apart this time.”

“It’s a low bar, but I’ll allow it,” Catra teased.

In between bites, Adora added, “They’re great, Bow.”

Glimmer grinned, “Adora, maybe chew before reviewing?”

Catra laughed, “She’s just afraid Bow won’t let her have a second one if she doesn't compliment him fast enough.”

Adora pushed her shoulder playfully even as she did reach over for another sandwich, and soon all four were laughing as they fully enjoyed this moment together and breathed in the calm before the coming storm.

Each night, the desert found Adora again in her dreams. It didn’t speak now, it just watched. The monolith, the hum of the magic, and the unrelenting heat were ever-present. Once, she saw herself walking across endless dunes, glowing faintly and barely leaving footprints. Magic seemed to swirl behind her like a trailing shadow.

She’d wake with her heart racing, but not with the same full-on panic as the first dream. Now, she just looked over and found Catra curled nearby, one hand flung out in her direction like Catra’s body knew somehow to find and protect Adora even in sleep. Adora would take that hand, feel its comforting squeeze, and she’d be able to sleep again, grounded by Catra’s presence and love.

By the end of the second day, the shields and tether were holding well, amplified by the tracker pad’s pulsing signal. They felt confident that they had prepared as much as they could to face the threat ahead. Glimmer had also crafted a small violet crystal set into a pendant. It pulsed faintly in tune with Adora’s own magic. It would help stabilize her further.

Catra brushed her thumb over the pendant as if to validate its strength and confirm it would protect Adora. She carefully tucked the pendant beneath Adora’s collar, fingers lingering just a little longer than necessary.

“Don’t drop it,” she murmured.

“I won’t,” Adora promised, feeling the steady warmth of the pendant against her pulse point. It felt stabilizing and like a physical reminder of her friends’ care and strength.

They stood together on the balcony then, watching the afternoon moons slowly sink below the horizon. The pinks and purples of dusk began to fill the sky. Tomorrow they’d return and face the desert again. But tonight, they just relaxed in the comfort of one another.

Adora leaned into Catra’s side, and Catra’s arm came up around her shoulders like it belonged there. Adora rested her head against Catra’s shoulder, and Catra’s tail wound around her wrist without thinking. They stayed together like that for a while before deciding that they should head to bed. They needed to get sufficient rest to be ready for the next day.

They woke at first light and readied to transport to the desert. Glimmer’s magic shimmered around them and dropped them at the base of the ridge. Pink teleportation sparks fizzled out as their feet sank into steadily warming sand.

Adora took in a deep breath. She could feel the power of the rising magic all around her now. It was a persistent pulse in the air that seemed to press uncomfortably against every inch of her skin. She hoped she was ready for this. She wanted, no, needed to be ready to face this magic again.

Chapter 9

Early morning light streamed through the desert, gleaming across endless dunes and wide expanses of shimmering golden sand. They set up a small camp beneath a rock outcropping, a small distance from the basin where the monolith stood. It wasn't much of a camp as they didn't plan to stay long. They had laid out a few cloaks in the narrow shade and had a pack set nearby with water, dried food, and some other essential supplies.

By mid-morning, they headed the short walk down to the basin and entered it through a gap in the surrounding ring of stone jutting irregularly from the sand. The monolith came into view, red-gold like a shard of fire turned to stone, gleaming tall and narrow in the bright light of the desert with glowing spiral symbols flickering on its surface. It seemed even more imposing than Adora remembered.

Adora pushed off a rising feeling of anxiety as she stepped forward, feeling her protective pendant warm against her pulse point and trying to take strength from its power and its symbolism as protection from her friends who now stood right beside her. She swallowed the lump in her throat and summoned her strength as she asked Glimmer with all the resolve she could muster, "Ready?"

Glimmer nodded determinedly, and with well-practiced motions, she swung her right arm downward and her left arm upward, creating a circle of glowing pink energy. A magical symbol composed of concentric circles surrounding diamonds and moons shimmered into the air before her. The energy flickered outward, creating a translucent bubble of protection all around them, the glowing symbol imprinting into the ground beneath their feet in glowing lines, strong and steady.

Catra stood just behind Adora with her hand pressed gently against her back to anchor her. They both concentrated for a few moments and let their energy flow between them to strengthen

the tether. Adora felt a faint warmth buzzing comfortably in her chest.

With a slow exhale, Adora readied herself and said carefully, “Okay, let’s try this.”

She reached inside for the magic within her. She couldn't yet transform, but she felt the hum of her magic deep inside her. She pressed a palm to the desert floor, willing a gentle connection to form. The monolith pulsed in answer, immediate and alive. For a moment, it seemed to recognize her, to accept her greeting, but then it reacted.

A powerful pulse rushed toward them and strained at their shielding spell. Sand whipped up around them despite there being no wind, and the temperature inside shot up. Adora’s breath tightened in her chest, and her pulse pounded.

“Back off now!” Glimmer shouted.

Bow dropped to one knee with his tracker pad and frantically adjusted its frequencies to try and further amplify their protective magic.

Catra gripped Adora’s shoulders tightly as she felt the bond between them weakening under the intensity of the magic response. She pulled Adora back forcefully, and as Adora lifted her hand off the ground, the connection severed and the pressure around them instantly eased.

They all stood silent, taking in the intensity of what had just happened. Their protections had held, and no one had been hurt. Still, the desert’s response, its defense, had been more extreme than they had anticipated or imagined during their preparations.

“That was worse than I expected,” Bow said, with a grimace.

Catra didn’t say anything yet, her jaw just tightened.

Adora exhaled suddenly, like she had just remembered how to properly breathe, and turned to Glimmer. “We can’t force it like this.”

“No,” Glimmer agreed, her voice a bit strained from having maintained her spell against such power. “It’s too volatile. We’re going to need a new approach.”

“Tomorrow,” Catra said quickly. “We’re not trying again today.”

Adora started to argue, wanting to just push forward now that they were here, but she stopped. She realized that the weight of that encounter was still pressing on her chest and she didn’t really have a good alternate plan in mind. So with a resigned sigh, she said, “Okay, we’ll rest and rethink this.”

They headed back to their camp, all still processing and lost in their own thoughts. They sat on their cloaks in the shade, backs pressed against the rock outcropping. They drank water and ate dried food, just decompressing and trying to get themselves to unwind a bit.

Bow started fiddling with his tracker pad. Glimmer muttered to herself about enhanced spell stability and possible changes

Catra sat beside Adora. Her tail flicked once across the ground before curling around her ankle. “You okay?” she asked softly.

Adora nodded, and they sat there side by side, just leaning against one another for a long moment.

The afternoon moons began to sink below the horizon as the sky began to pinken and then darken with dusk. The four of them were gathered atop their cloaks spread over the sand.

Adora now sat with her arms wrapped around her knees. Her body was taut, like every muscle was bracing for something she couldn’t quite name.

They hadn’t said much to each other since heading back. The magic’s rejection still hung heavy around them.

“I think we came in too strong,” Glimmer said at last. “Too much protective magic. Too much power all at once.”

“You think it felt threatened?” Bow asked.

“I think it felt challenged.” She looked over at Adora. “And it doesn’t trust us.”

Catra sighed, “Great. So now we’re negotiating with a cursed magic stone.”

“It’s not just the stone,” Adora murmured. “It’s everything out there. The land, the wind, the sand. It feels like the whole desert is watching me. It’s like I did something wrong just by being here.”

“You didn’t,” Catra said, sharp and immediate. “You didn’t do anything wrong.”

Adora didn’t answer, she just tightened her grip around her knees and cast her eyes downward.

“We need to talk about tonight. I’ll cast a protective shield, and Bow will have the signal from his tracker pad monitoring it and enhancing it,” Glimmer explained.

“I’ll take first watch,” Catra said quickly.

“I’ll take second,” Glimmer added.

Adora frowned. “You guys don’t have to do that.”

“Yes, we do,” Catra cut in. She turned to face her fully. “We’re not going to risk it sneaking up on you again. Not like last time.”

Adora opened her mouth to argue, but instead, she nodded slowly. “Okay.”

On one hand, she felt a bit distressed that they felt the need to protect her like this when she was meant to be their strongest warrior, but on the other, she felt deeply cared for and loved, and that feeling was winning out for now.

Glimmer and Bow set to work getting the spell and device in place. Soon, a shimmering pink protective dome enclosed them once more. It felt fortified, if not quite fully safe.

The sky darkened to a deep inky black, small pinpricks of light appearing until the sky was painted with layer upon layer of faintly glowing stars. Adora lay resting on a cloak in the shelter of the rock wall, gazing up at the sky.

Catra sat beside her, on watch, back straight and eyes alert. "Try to sleep," she said gently, brushing Adora's hair back. "We've got you."

Adora gave her a tired smile. "You always make it sound easy."

"It's not, but we do it anyway."

Adora's eyes fluttered shut, and the desert night pressed close.

The dream came quickly. She was standing alone before the red-gold monolith. It stood there just waiting for her. The sky was a violet tone that didn't belong to any known time of day.

She felt her feet move forward as if outside her control. No, she would not do this again. She resisted, gritting her teeth and turning her body away from the pull and trying to focus on the feeling of Catra's presence beside her that she couldn't see in the dream but knew was still there.

An otherworldly voice echoed around and through her, like a deep whisper curling through the air. "You came back."

Adora didn't answer. She didn't want to answer. She clung to her inner strength and to the anchor of Catra and her friends and the protective magic that wrapped around her in the real world. The

desert waited patient and vast, but still Adora willed herself not to speak and not to move.

Outside the dream, Catra watched over her carefully, noting each twitch of her brow and each flicker of tension in her shoulders. Catra's tail curled tightly around her own ankle as she sat rigid, unwilling to look away even for a second. She didn't know what Adora was seeing in her dream, but she could see that she was fighting it, and hopefully that would be enough.

Catra would stay right beside her, hopefully grounding her, as it was all that she could do. As much as she would like to, she couldn't fight off whatever Adora faced in her dream, so she would just stay close and hopefully that too would be enough.



Chapter 10

The dreamscape felt surreal and timeless. The wind moved in unnatural rhythms as if it had whims and a mind of its own. Adora stood before the monolith, which loomed expectantly before her. She had managed to resist its pull, and so she stayed staring at it from a small distance rather than being vulnerable and unwillingly pressed against it like before.

“You came back,” the ethereal voice repeated in its low whispering tone that seemed to resonate through her very body rather than just her ears.

This time, instead of resisting a response, Adora decided that she would carefully engage, not from a forced compulsion but through her own will to try and forge some sort of understanding.

“I didn’t come to hurt you,” she said aloud. Her own voice sounded small in the vastness of the glowing sand and violet sky surrounding her.

“Hurt has already come.” The voice echoed once more, and images flashed before her eyes. They were not her own memories, but rather the memories of the desert.

Pulsing green lines threaded through the ground, corroding the land. The infection Prime had released to acquire the Heart. Then the towering beams of spiraling green energy cracked through the earth, tearing it apart as the power of the Heart began to release for Prime. Then, the change as it was quickly absorbed and then released once more in ripples of prismatic rainbow light and the rapid growth and renewal that echoed across the planet, rapidly spreading trapped magic outward to the very edges of Etheria. Golden sparkles dancing through the air.

“You’re… remembering,” Adora whispered. “You're alive.”

“You turned us off. Then turned us loose.” The voice crackled now, brittle with something between accusation and sorrow.

Adora’s heart pounded as realization struck her. The magic had been familiar because it was part of the magic she herself had held that night at the Heart. “I didn’t know. I didn’t understand what would happen.”

“You understand now.”

She flinched, not because it was angry, but because it wasn’t. It was actually hurt and afraid. “I want to fix this,” she said. “I came back to fix it.”

The dream wind slowed as if listening for a beat. Adora pressed a hand to her chest and made a soft plea. “You have to let me try.

The wind returned then, faster this time, almost like it was panicked. The dreamscape began to blur. The monolith in the distance cracked with a seam of light down its center. The voice echoed through her softly once more, “Then try.”

Back in the desert, Adora twitched in her sleep. A soft sound escaped her lips, just barely audible, but enough to draw Catra’s attention.

Catra was now curled beside her after Glimmer had quietly relieved her watch. She shifted closer, one arm sliding over Adora’s waist. Her head tucked just under Adora’s chin, and her tail flicked once, then stilled. “You’re okay,” she murmured. “I’m right here, remember?”

Adora didn’t wake, but her breath steadied. Catra let herself drift then, listening to the soft breaths of the girl she refused to leave. Who she had promised herself she would always protect. In the hush of the night, they lay together, shielded by wards and willpower and a worn-down but still persistent sense of hope.

The first light of dawn broke across the sand. Adora stirred awake and pushed herself slowly upright. Her body felt a bit heavy with

tension leftover from her dream. Her mind, though, was clear and full of a new understanding of what she really faced.

Catra was still dozing lightly beside her with one hand still touching Adora's side. Her ears flicked when Adora shifted, and within seconds, sharp mismatched eyes blinked open.

"You're up," Catra murmured. She pushed herself up on an elbow, studying her with practiced care. "You okay?"

Adora nodded. "Yeah." Then she glanced sideways, and her brows furrowed. "It talked to me again."

That made Catra fully awake. "It?" she asked. "The magic?"

Adora nodded slowly. "Words and visions. It's not trying to hurt us. It's… reacting."

"Reacting how?" Glimmer asked, her gaze on Adora. She and Bow had awoken to the conversation.

Adora hesitated, unsure how best to convey what she had learned. "It remembers what Prime did," she said at last. "It remembers being corrupted, turned off and back on. Feeling like it was used and controlled. The Heart's release didn't just restore things. It shocked the system."

Bow's face fell. "So we did hurt it."

"Not on purpose," Adora said quickly. "But yeah. I think that's where the pain comes from. And it's not just pain. It's scared."

Catra narrowed her eyes. "You're telling me the desert magic is afraid of you?"

Adora shrugged, knowing it was a bit strange, but it seemed to be the truth. "I think it's afraid of being manipulated again. I think it thought I was a threat at first, but I think now it might let me help."

A silence settled around the camp as they all processed what Adora had learned in her dream.

Glimmer looked down at her lap, then back at Adora. “Okay, so we don’t use as much defensive magic this time.”

Adora nodded, “Yeah, I think I need to try to earn its trust. So we’ll have to do it without the shield.” She wrapped her arm around her side, feeling a bit nervous at the thought. She wanted to do this right, but she couldn’t help still being a bit wary.

Glimmer said, “Okay. Bow and I will keep back, just at the ready in case you need us.”

Catra sat back with a long breath, tail flicking behind her. “Well,” she said dryly, “at least we’re good at trust exercises these days.”

Adora gave her a small smile. “I trust you.”

“Obviously,” Catra replied quickly, then softened, looking away just for a moment. “You’d better.”

Catra leaned into Adora, their shoulders touching. “So what’s your plan?”

Adora looked out across the sand, toward the basin where she knew the monolith was waiting for her. She exhaled slowly. “I go in as myself,” she said. “Well, maybe, me and you.” She turned to Catra. “If you’re still okay being my tether.”

Catra’s answer was immediate. “Always.”

Chapter 11

The monolith stood towering upward from the sand like a glowing pillar of fire made solid. Its shadow stretched in a formidable shaft that cut clear across the basin. As they neared it, the pause in the desert wind felt like a held breath.

They approached slowly this time with no shielding spells or pendants. Glimmer and Bow stayed back near the stone rim. Adora walked slowly forward toward the place that had once stolen her strength and silenced her voice. Catra stayed right beside her, always less than a pace away, providing silent support.

Adora stopped directly in front of the monolith. She felt Catra press a comforting hand against her shoulder. She let it steady her nerves as she felt the warm hum within her of their tethered energy.

The air of the basin felt heavy. It was expectant, like it remembered her, like it knew her. Adora exhaled slowly and raised her hands slightly outward with her palms turned upward in a gesture of openness.

"I'm not here to hurt you," she said quietly. "I'm just here to try and help."

The wind suddenly whipped around her, and Adora felt an intense wave of pressure against her skin. Her chest tightened, and then she felt her legs lock. Her throat began closing up as the sensations of her own body suddenly felt outside of her control.

It was the same way it had taken hold of her that morning when it had nearly let her roast in the desert heat. Her vision began to swim and her heart to pound as panic threatened to overwhelm her. Once again, she found that she was paralyzed. She couldn't move. She couldn't speak.

“Adora. Hey.” Catra’s voice, grounding and real, right beside her. “Look at me.”

She managed it, just barely. Her eyes snapped to Catra’s own mismatched pair.

“You’re not alone,” Catra said, squeezing her shoulder. “You’re not trapped. You’re right here, with me. I’ve got you.”

Adora’s vision cleared, and her fingers slowly twitched. The pressure didn’t fully release, but it faltered. It was almost like a blink of confusion.

Catra threaded her hand with Adora’s and gave a reassuring squeeze. “You’re stronger than this. We are stronger than it.”

Adora focused now with everything in her. She took in and released a few deep, steadying breaths. And then, she willed herself to step forward, and the spell of paralysis that had so suddenly gripped her broke.

The desert magic surged up in a wave of heat that felt filled with memory and pain. Now, it no longer overwhelmed her. Instead, it met her. It swirled around her, and she could feel its aching and its fear. It felt like a familiar echo that was looking for a way to heal, a hand to hold.

Adora held out her open palm once more. The monolith responded, not in defense now, but in an exhale of unreleased tension.

Her voice returned and she said softly but with conviction, “I know what it’s like to be used and then to be freed. To not know what to do with that freedom. To not know if that freedom would last, if it was really freedom at all. Just like you, I was afraid that I would be controlled over and over, but I believe now that we can both be free. Please let me help you now to be truly free.”

She reached deep inside of herself, her heart open, and the last of her fear melted away. Her eyes blazed with light, and a golden

glow surrounded her as she transformed. It was not a blinding light, but softened by everything Adora had learned and the kinship she felt for the magic in this moment.

Her sword materialized in her hand. She knew it was not to be used as a weapon but as a conduit. She pressed the blade gently against the base of the stone and felt her healing magic flow softly toward the monolith as an offering.

The desert wind whirled in a spiral around them. The air resonated with a low tone that felt like the desert was finally remembering how to breathe, the once defensive and violent urges softening in peace and a feeling of release. The fiery glow of the monolith faded from within it, leaving behind plain desert rock and just the soft golden traces of Etheria's gentle and natural magic. The aggressive force was now subdued and fully healed.

Adora released her transformation, a deep sense of ease settling within her at the peaceful sight now before her.

"You did it," Catra murmured, squeezing her hand once more. "You actually did it."

Adora leaned into her, pressing her forehead to Catra's. "We did it."

The afternoon moon had sunk low in the sky by the time they left the monolith behind. The wind had quieted as if the desert itself was resting at last. They headed back to their camp. Adora leaned a bit into Catra, tired from her efforts. Catra didn't mind, supporting her as she always would when she needed it.

Glimmer appeared beside them with a grin and a full canteen. "You just healed the wounds of an entire desert."

They could all feel it. The air was different now. It was calmer and lighter. The desert magic no longer thrummed with tension. Now, it was woven peacefully back into the land.

"Yeah," Bow said. "You really helped it."

They gathered up their supplies by the rock outcropping, taking in their last views of the endless expanses of shimmering sand and the awe-inspiring, but no longer to be feared, desert.

Glimmer asked, “Everyone ready?”

Adora nodded, her fingers finding Catra’s and squeezing them. The desert shimmered, and in a flurry of pink sparks, Bright Moon’s courtyard unfolded around them.

The evening was soft and golden. They didn’t make a grand return. Just a shared meal in the quiet of the evening, and the peaceful moments that followed a hard-earned victory.

Later, Adora sat on the edge of their bed, and Catra slid down beside her. “Let’s sleep like people who just saved a desert.”

As they curled into each other, a large glowing moon rose outside their window. Before they drifted off peacefully together, Adora gave Catra a wide smile filled once more with a restored optimism that no cursed magic would ever truly be able to take away from her.

End Notes

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